

Marketing and Data Sets

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The future of marketing is data, which means marketers need to be proficient at analyzing the audience information that comes their way in order to gain insights that will inform their marketing strategy going forward. But this data needs to come from somewhere. As a marketer, you'll need to know what data to use, how to use it, and, more importantly, where it comes from and how to get it.



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What is a data set?

A data set is simply a collection of information, numbers, or other values related to a particular subject or audience.

What types of data sets are there?

There are data sets on everything! From ecommerce purchases to food consumption to airline safety to weather patterns, organizations collect data on many different subjects and in many different ways. This can help them identify patterns, understand their customers or the industry better, and make better business decisions.

What data sets are typically helpful to marketers?

Marketers tend to focus on data that will help them better understand their customers, and which will provide them information on demographics, interests, and behaviors. This can be in the form of:

- **first-party data, which organizations collect themselves**
- **second-party data, which is data shared from another organization**
- **third-party data, which is collected by a third party**

Ultimately, the mostly helpful data sets will be the one that helps you achieve your marketing goals.

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How are data sets collected?

Customer data can be collected by the company Itself through social media or web analytics data, POS information, customer feedback, and more. Or, there are third-party organizations who regularly track different types of data that may be helpful to marketers. This is typically done through either panel-based measures, where data is collected from a small group, or approaches that look at metrics industry-wide. Information can be collected through surveys, interviews, pixel tracking, or other methods.

How can marketers use data sets?

Marketers use data sets to better understand who their customer is, which can allow them to better target their audience with their marketing efforts. Data informs marketers about who their customer is and what they respond to, their everyday actions and interactions, and their past purchasing behavior, which helps marketers make data-informed decisions on future strategy — rather than just guessing or "going by their gut."

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What are some of the common data sets that marketers use?

Marketers often work with data that's been internally collected, like:

- **Web analytics:** Data from website tracking can give marketers insight into their audience, their behavior while browsing, which web pages are most popular, and conversion rates.
- **Social media analytics:** Data from social media can provide insights on audience demographics, engagement, and which posts are prompting followers to take action.
- **POS databases:** Data from point of sale systems can keep track of inventory and customer purchases, and give insights into customer behavior.
- **Customer database/CRM:** Businesses can use a database to track customer information, including age, location, contact information, gender, interests, and more.
- **Campaign analytics**: Marketers can use the data from their advertising campaigns to better understand which marketing efforts resonate with their audience, which creative results in the most conversions, and which campaigns are unsuccessful.
- **Surveys/feedback**: Marketers can also learn more about their customers directly from them through customer feedback surveys, focus groups, and more.

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Marketers can also work with data that's been collected by another party, and while it may not contain information on specific individual customers, it can give insights into target audiences in general, local markets, industry trends, and more. Examples include:

- **Census Bureau:** Marketers can use Census Bureau data not only for demographic information, but can use the various data sets on their website to understand the populations of different areas (e.g., neighborhoods surrounding brick-and-mortar stores), including wealth concentration, who's renting or buying, commuting patterns, where other businesses are located, and other useful information.
- **Data.gov:** Marketers can use the open-source data on Data.gov to learn about a variety of topics from various agencies, including economic and commerce data like retail trade surveys, ecommerce reports, building permit information, and more.
- **Comscore:** Marketers can use Comscore ratings and data to learn more about an audience and their media consumption, from data gathered from panel participants who opt in to have their device usage tracked.
- **Nielsen:** Marketers can use Nielsen — most known for their tracking of TV-watching habits — to learn more about their audience's media consumption across devices and media. Nielsen Audio, formerly Arbitron, measures radio and podcast data as well. Nielsen also oversees Nielsen Scarborough, which offers localized market research and consumer insights.



- **PRIZM (Potential Rating Index for Zip Markets): Marketers can use PRIZM data to learn more about the demographics, tech usage, purchasing behavior, and other interests of 68 specific customer segments based on socio-economic status.**
- **MRI-Simmons: Marketers can use MRI-Simmons data to better understand consumer attitudes and behaviors, market trends, and buying habits, which they gather through surveys and passive measurement.**
- **Quantcast: Marketers can use Quantcast data to gain insights into audience demographics and behavior across websites and apps in real time via AI and machine learning.**
- **Pew Research: Marketers can use Pew Research to gain insights on nearly everything measurable, including who's using which social media platforms, how many people are shopping online, tech trends, and other researched reports.**

There are numerous other sources where marketers can find data about consumer demographics and behaviors as well, like industry reports, trade journals, aggregator websites, research firms, and many other sources that either collect data themselves, or sell it for others. Investigate how the data was collected and its sampling methods before purchase, in order to ensure that it will ultimately be useful and valuable to your marketing efforts.

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